A FREE CASE FROM ASHCOMBE MANOR

A Friday at Ashcombe

In 1931, every Friday at seven o'clock, the gates of Ashcombe Manor were locked and Lord Ashcombe's guests played a game. His secretary, Miss Pell, dealt each guest a card in silence: one said victim, one said murderer. The lamps went out for one minute. When they came back on, nobody was allowed to move, and Miss Pell went from room to room with her notebook.

HOW TO PLAY

1. **Every statement is true.** Read each one against the plan.
2. **Exactly one suspect stands in every row and every column.** The body is not a suspect. Areas have no such rule: an area may hold several suspects, or none.
3. **The murderer is the one suspect in the area with the body.** That area always holds exactly one suspect, and the rule works while you solve: once one suspect must be there, nobody else can be.

Rows are numbered from the top and columns from the left, so R2C5 is the second row, fifth column; north is the top of the plan. Hatched squares are where nobody can stand. A dark outline around a whole square means nobody can see past it, like a wall. Write initials on the plan as you go: small where a suspect *might* be, large where they *must* be. There is exactly one answer, and you never need to guess.

Beside: in a square next to it, up, down, left or right, and in the same area. Never diagonally, and never through a wall or a doorway. Sitting or standing on something, a chair or a rug, is not being beside it, but another one next to your square is.

In a corner: on a square where two walls of its own area meet, one above or below it and one to its side. A doorway counts as wall here, and so does the edge of the plan.

Wore, had: what the lineup shows under each suspect's picture. *Everyone beside a clock, if anyone, had a beard* does not say that anyone stood beside one.

A Friday at Ashcombe

GENTLE



Seven o'clock on a Friday, and the gates of Ashcombe Manor were locked. Miss Pell dealt the cards in silence, the lamps went out for one minute, and when they came back on, Sam lay in the Study.

THE CLUES

1. Agatha was beside a china cabinet.
2. Douglas was beside a bed.
3. Nora was beside the couch in the Conservatory.
4. Jack was in the third row.
5. Clara was not beside a stove.
6. Edith was not in a corner.

GENERAL CLUES

7. The person in the third column wore no monocle.

THE SUSPECTS



1. Jack
a fedora
a beard



2. Douglas
a monocle
a beard



3. Agatha
a fedora
spectacles



4. Clara
a bowler
spectacles



5. Edith
a fedora
a monocle



6. Nora
a fedora
a monocle

THE MURDERER

_____

The Furniture

Every piece in this case, drawn as on the plan, and the two things that matter about each: whether a suspect can stand on its square, and whether a suspect can see past it.



bed

✗ nobody can stand here
✓ can see past it



bookcase

✗ nobody can stand here
✗ blocks the view



china cabinet

✗ nobody can stand here
✗ blocks the view



couch

✓ can sit or stand here
✓ can see past it



grandfather clock

✗ nobody can stand here
✗ blocks the view



mirror

✗ nobody can stand here
✗ blocks the view



potted plant

✗ nobody can stand here
✗ blocks the view



rug

✓ can sit or stand here
✓ can see past it



stove

✗ nobody can stand here
✗ blocks the view





table

✗ nobody can stand here
✓ can see past it



writing desk

✗ nobody can stand here
✓ can see past it

Stuck?

Three hints, each giving away a little more than the last. Read one, then go back to the plan.

Hint I · Where to begin. Start with Agatha. Read against the plan, clue 1 leaves her exactly one square.

Hint II · When you are stuck. Read clues 2 and 7 together: they are enough to place the next suspect. Clue 7 is about what people wore, and it applies to Douglas: find him in the lineup, then read the clue against the squares still open to him. By this point one suspect should be placed.

Hint III · A checkpoint. Agatha at R2C1, Douglas at R5C4, Edith at R1C5.

Who did it?

The answer, step by step, comes by email in two days. No peeking until then.

Fifty more cases

Miss Pell wrote every game into a ledger: a whole year of Fridays at Ashcombe Manor, from the first daffodils to the last of the snow. **Whereabouts: Murder Sudoku — 50 Murder Mysteries from Ashcombe Manor** is that ledger, with a practice case solved for you, three levels of hints for every case, and the answers step by step.

And every Friday, a new case is free at **whereaboutspuzzles.com**.

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